

## CUSTOMS PILOTS ASYCUDA WORLD

**Uganda Revenue Authority's** Customs Department is migrating from the old Customs management system namely ASYCUDA++ to a modern version the ASYCUDA WORLD. It is being piloted in Jinja before it rolls out to the rest of the country. **Commissioner Customs, Richard Kamajugo** in an interview explained the reasons for the move. Below are excerpts.



### 1. What is ASYCUDA?

ASYCUDA stands for **Automated System for Customs Data**. Over time, the system evolved from ASYCUDA 2.7, ASYCUDA ++ up to current ASYCUDA World. URA used ASYCUDA ++ since 2003 and is now migrating to ASYCUDA World.

Asycuda World is web-based and supports paper-less declaration processing through use of electronic documents, and most Customs processes are automated.

In 2011 URA decided to upgrade from Asycuda++ to Asycuda World in order to respond to the ever-changing business needs. Asycuda World is more robust and flexible and, therefore, able to adapt to the different settings, It also provides an easier channel for interconnectivity with other systems.

### 2. When is the system coming into force?

Piloting of the system commenced on 26<sup>th</sup> November 2012 at the Jinja Customs office. The Pilot will run for three months before rolling out to other stations.

### 3. Why is it important and what is it exactly expected to cure?

Asycuda World is a web-enabled system that allows traders/agents to submit their declarations for clearance of goods through Customs from anywhere through the internet. Other benefits include:

- It is possible to attach & submit commercial documents electronically
- Paperless declaration processing
- The system can easily interact with other IT systems in URA and other Government agencies

### 4. What kind of Impact will it have in clearance of consignment at the border points?

- It will save clearance time since its web based.

Easing the clearance process will encourage voluntary compliance

- Improved management and statistical reporting, to facilitate Government planning.
- Communication – Asycuda World offers an enhanced e-mail platform which also supports attachments. For example, you only need attach the declaration and forward it to another user for further action.

## **5. How does it work?**

The programme is computer based. A client needs a computer (laptop or desktop with 50 Gigabytes (Gb) of Hard disk and at least 1 Gb of random access memory (RAM) and internet connectivity.

One then has to log into the ASYCUDA World system and this will enable to monitor the status of their declarations from anywhere as long as they have internet connectivity.

Electronic messages in form of e-mails and SMS shall be sent to the traders at various stages of declaration processing.

## **6. Asycuda++ had disruptions recently. How reliable is the new system and has it got a fall back in case of interruption and or disruptions?**

ASYCUDA World has been successful in over 30 countries in Africa. Neighboring countries like Zimbabwe, Rwanda and Ethiopia have implemented Asycuda World. URA is confident that the system will be a success in Uganda.

## **7. What are some of the challenges the system could have?**

None so far. Internet is fairly stable. Therefore, the system should perform optimally as expected.

## **8. Is this system going to be used at all border points or only at Malaba, Eastern Uganda where clearance is quite heavy?**

The system will gradually be available at all URA customs offices. By December 2013, it will be in use at all Customs stations countrywide.

## **9. What are the immediate and long term benefits of this system to the tax payer?**

- It will significantly reduce unnecessary delays in the clearance processes.
- The system also offers a platform for linking other Government agencies.
- Further, the system will improve ensure transparency and credibility by sending real time feedback to taxpayers.

## **10. How will Asycuda World specifically improve Clearing time?**

- Asycuda World offers the opportunity for multi-agency risk management which will allow independent risk profiles by each border agency to be applied during declaration processing.
- Faster declaration processing – this is available even before undertaking detailed business process re-engineering because of the elimination of the need to move physical documents from one process stage to another. For example, customs can immediately start processing a declaration as soon as a payment is registered at the bank.
- Single Window platform – Asycuda World offers a platform which other Government agencies can use as a basis during the implementation.
- Use of pre-arrival information
- Capability to use multiple devices – Asycuda World offers the capability to use mobile devices for examiners to update the Inspection Act. It also offers quick retrieval of entries using devices like barcode readers, Scanners, etc., which can be used by mobile teams.

**ENDS**